ruled. Indian ('Hindu') servility came from a history of living under 'despotic' rule without rights and without regard for truth and honesty. This was an image that the British would propagate about China as well: the rulers of these Asian societies in effect had deserved to lose control of their territories to outsiders because they had failed to look after the security and welfare of their subjects.

By the 1890s, Wagner shows, the Chinese were getting 'a steady stream of mostly commercial and political news about India'. After China was defeated by Japan in the Sino-Japanese war, the British missionary journalist Timothy Richard wrote about the benefits of crown rule in India (when it supplanted the East India Company) – he had been asked to submit to the Chinese imperial government ideas about governance reforms. Robert MacKenzie's *The Nineteenth Century*, which reflected similarly on British rule in India, was made compulsory reading for Chinese officials in 1898.[19] Emerging Chinese intellectuals such as Kang Youwei and Liang Qichao, fearful that a backward China would be partitioned after it was defeated by Japan, set up reform newspapers and became loud and critical voices for change.

Wagner's fascinating study of the period shows that the young reformers urged China to emulate Japan, Russia, and Germany in their reform process and not to go the way of societies like India. At the heart of their view was that internal weakness more than imperialism was the cause of Indian national decay. For Liang, China could avoid the fate of India (and others) because the 'yellow' races were as talented as the 'white' – by implication this was not the case with the other races. Liang and others also had access to Japanese writings about India. These writings, too, blamed India's internal weakness, not imperialism, for its decline and colonization.[20] A group of Chinese students in Japan ran a series of articles on India in 1903, titled 'The Causes for the Demise of India'. Drawing on Japanese sources, the articles produced a damning picture of India. The tone of the writing is by turns contemptuous, exasperated, and melancholy:

> [T]he word 'India' is in fact nothing but a name from history. Aya! Their land is all smashed to pieces . . . this brown race will be forever enslaved . . . Looking at China today, it is like India in